SMALL-GROUP GUIDE

The Book in the Rubble

Huldah · 2 Kings 22:14–20

Text: 2 Kings 22:14–20 (with 2 Kings 22:1–23:30; 2 Chronicles 34:1–33; Deuteronomy 28–29; Jeremiah 31:31–34; Galatians 3:10–14) **Big idea:** The word of God found in the rubble wounds the proud, hears the humble, and points to the King who took its curse: Huldah spoke the word, Josiah reformed the nation, and Jesus bore the judgment. **Time:** 60–75 minutes

Before you meet. Read 2 Kings 22:14–20 aloud three times. Then read 2 Kings 22:1–23:30 and 2 Chronicles 34. Mark what the text says about Huldah and what it leaves out. Read Deuteronomy 28:15 and Galatians 3:10–14.

OPEN (5 MINUTES)

Pray. Read 2 Kings 22:14–20 aloud. Ask: "What is the strangest thing about this story?" Let people answer before you teach.

OBSERVE (15 MINUTES)

1. **The find.** What did Hilkiah find, and why did the king tear his clothes (2 Kings 22:8–11)? What does Deuteronomy 28:15 tell us about what he had just heard?
2. **The delegation.** Who goes to Huldah (22:12–14)? What does the list of names tell us about how seriously the king took the book?

INTERPRET (20 MINUTES)

3. **The prophetess.** What does the text tell us about Huldah, and what does it leave out? Why does the narrator include the Second Quarter and her husband's court position?
4. **The two halves.** How does Huldah hold judgment and mercy together (22:16–20)? Why does she not soften the first or universalize the second?
5. **The promise.** Huldah says Josiah will be gathered to his grave in peace, yet he dies in battle at Megiddo (23:29–30). How do you reconcile the two? What kind of promise was it?
6. **The reform.** Why does the most thorough reform in Judah's history not turn away the wrath (23:25–27)? What does that teach us about the law and the heart (Galatians 3:10–14; Jeremiah 31:31–34)?

APPLY (20 MINUTES)

7. **The tender heart.** When has the Word wounded you? How did you respond? Where are you tempted to skip straight to comfort without letting the verdict land?
8. **The messenger.** Whose voice have you dismissed because of who they are or how they said it? How can you test the message by the book rather than by the messenger?

CLOSE (5 MINUTES)

Invite each person to finish one sentence: "The word I most need to hear is ____. The reform I most need to do is ____." No one has to report it.

Pray: "Lord Jesus, your word is true, and we are not. Give us tender hearts. Give us the humility to hear you through the messengers you send. Give us the courage to do the reform you ask, and the grace to trust the King who took the curse. Amen."

Remind them: the invitation is not "be a better Josiah." It is "come to the greater King."

LEADER NOTES

- **The text.** The primary narrative is 2 Kings 22:14–20; the parallel is 2 Chronicles 34:22–28. Kings puts the finding in Josiah's eighteenth year and the reform after; Chronicles places some reforms earlier (34:3–7). Follow the Kings sequence and note the difference if asked.
- **The book.** "The Book of the Law" is widely identified with Deuteronomy or a core of it; the reform's centralization, covenant, and Passover are Deuteronomy-shaped. The text does not specify the scroll's extent. Do not invent the discovery scene.
- **Huldah.** Prophetess; wife of Shallum son of Tikvah son of Harhas, keeper of the wardrobe; lives in the Second Quarter (Mishneh), likely the newer western district. Rabbinic traditions link her family to Joshua and Rahab (b. Megillah 14b); label these as later tradition, not text. The narrative does not comment on her gender; note the significance without a slogan.
- **The promise.** "Gathered to your grave in peace" (22:20) is not a promise of a painless life. Josiah dies at Megiddo at thirty-nine (23:29) but is buried in his own tomb before Jerusalem falls (23:30). The promise is kept in its own terms; do not turn it into a prosperity promise.
- **The reform.** 2 Kings 23:25 is the highest royal commendation in Kings; 23:26–27 says the wrath was not turned away. The point is not that reform was useless, but that law-keeping cannot atone for covenant-breaking. The new covenant promises a new heart (Jeremiah 31:31–34; Ezekiel 36:25–27); Jesus redeems from the curse (Galatians 3:10–14; 2 Corinthians 5:21; Romans 8:1–4).
- **Care.** If anyone discloses abuse or self-harm, follow safeguarding and connect them to pastoral care. Do not rush to "reform" language over a wound that needs lament and safety.